

Session 13: Jesus Tested in the Wilderness

Key Takeaways

- The Spirit leading Jesus into the wilderness signals an apocalyptic vision journey, like that of many other prophets before Jesus.
- Jesus' 40 days in the wilderness mirror Israel's 40 years in the wilderness.
- The slanderer's opening assault, "If you are the Son of God" (Matt. 4:3, 6), calls into question the identity that was affirmed in the previous story.
- The test about food is a choice, not about what is or isn't good, but about how and when you obtain the good—whether you will trust what God says in spite of appearances.

Jesus' Apocalyptic Journey

4:1 Then Jesus was led into the wilderness by **the spirit**,
to be tested by **the slanderer**,

Test 1

A ² and having **fasted** forty days and forty nights,
afterward he was **hungry**,

B ³ and approaching, **the tester** said to him,
" **If you are the son of God** ,
speak so that these stones become **loaves of bread**."

Deuteronomy 8:3

C ⁴ And responding, he said,
" **It has been written** ,
'Not by **bread** alone does humanity live,
but by every word that comes out from God's mouth.'"

Test 2

A' ⁵ Then **the slanderer** took him into **the holy city** ,
and he stationed him at the upper tip of **the temple** ,

⁶ and he said to him,
" **If you are the son of God** ,
throw yourself down,
B' **for it has been written** ,
'He has commanded his **messengers** concerning you,
and they will lift you up in their hands,
so that you won't strike your foot against a stone.'"

Deuteronomy 6:16

C' ⁷ Iesous said to him,
"Again, **it has been written** ,
'You will not **test** **the Lord your God** .'"

Test 3

A" ⁸ Again, **the slanderer** took him to **a high mountain** ,
and he showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their splendor,

⁹ and he said to him,
B" "All these things I will give to you,
if, falling down, you will **bow down** to me."

Deuteronomy 6:13

¹⁰ Then Iesous said to him,
"Be gone, adversary!
C" For **it has been written** ,
'You will **bow down** to **the Lord your God** ,
and you will **serve** him only.'"

¹¹ Then **the slanderer** left him,
and look, **messengers** approached and ministered to him.

The primary setting for this story is “in the wilderness” ([Matt. 4:1](#)), but notice that he is also suddenly transported to Jerusalem and the temple building and then to a high mountain ([Matt. 4:5, 8](#)). A common feature of prophetic apocalypses in later biblical tradition portrays the seer being led about by the Spirit or angelic guides.

Ezekiel 8:1-3 NIV

¹In the sixth year, in the sixth month on the fifth day, while I was sitting in my house and the elders of Judah were sitting before me, the hand of the Sovereign LORD came on me there. ... ³ **The Spirit lifted me up between earth and heaven and in visions of God he took me to Jerusalem ...**

Ezekiel 11:24 NIV

The Spirit lifted me up and brought me to the exiles in Babylonia in the vision given by the Spirit of God.

Revelation 1:9-10 LEB

⁹ I, John, your brother and co-sharer in the affliction and kingdom and steadfastness in Jesus, was **on the island called Patmos** because of the word of God and the testimony about Jesus. ¹⁰ **I was in the Spirit on the Lord’s day**, and I heard behind me a great sound like a trumpet

Revelation 4:1-2 LEB

¹ After these things I looked, and behold, **an open door in heaven**, and the former voice that I had heard like a trumpet speaking with me was saying, “**Come up here** and I will show you the things which must take place after these things.” ² Immediately **I was in the Spirit**, and behold, a throne was set in heaven, and one was seated on the throne.

Prophets are taken on apocalyptic journeys in order to reveal something to them or so they can face a test of trust that will determine what role they will play in the divine purpose (as in Ezekiel’s experience in [Ezek. 1-3](#) or [Isa. 6](#)). In this case, Jesus is taken to the wilderness for a journey that will put to the test whether Jesus trusts his true identity and character as the beloved Son.

Tested by the Slanderer

Slanderer: The “devil” is a translation from the Greek *diabolos* (διαβολος), which means “the slanderer” or “the accuser.” This word refers to the function that this spiritual being has within the assumed imagery of God’s divine council (see [Job 1-2](#) or [1 Kgs. 22](#)). God’s heavenly council room is presumed to be filled with various courtiers, one of whom accuses God’s chosen one to have some fault. God allows his chosen one to undergo hardship that will put to the test their loyalty and commitment to their calling.

“Tested” (Grk. *peirazo* / πειραζω): In the Bible, the testing of someone’s character is something that is done both by the snake-slanderer (as in [Matt. 4:1](#), [Luke 22:31-32](#), or [Job 1-2](#)), but also by God (see [Gen. 22:1](#) or [Exod. 20:18-20](#)).

- “Test” means to prove the truth about something through an ordeal that displays its character.
- Test is a word that comes from the world of blacksmithing, metallurgy, and stone-working.

Zechariah 13:9 NASB

And I will bring the third part through the fire, refine them as silver is refined, and **test them as gold is tested**. They will call on my name, and I will answer them; I will say, “They are my people,” and they will say, “The LORD is my God.”

Isaiah 28:16 NASB

Therefore thus says the Lord God, “Behold, I am laying in Zion a stone, **a tested stone**, a costly cornerstone for the foundation, firmly placed. He who believes in it will not be disturbed.”

In this context the test is about “stress-testing” an object to determine its true nature or reliability.

However, the nature of a test is determined by the intentions of the tester.

- A test is a trap when the purpose of the tester is to cause failure.
- A test is an opportunity when the purpose of the tester is to provide an opportunity to grow.

Jesus’ Tested Vocation

The focus of the test is clearly on Jesus’ identity and vocation as the beloved Son of God.

“The meaning of the ‘temptation story’ is not so much that Jesus was put in the way of sin and resisted it; rather, the story is about Jesus’ acceptance of his mission ... The Jesus who confronts us is not simply the one who has been tempted, but the one who has emerged from his ordeal ... Jesus was tested to see whether he was prepared to renounce the easy way of power and public success and obediently tread the hard road marked out by Isaiah’s servant ... The ‘get behind me Satan’ ... remark shows that Jesus faced an ordeal that tried him to the uttermost.”

Jeremias, Joachim (2012). [New Testament Theology](#). SCM Press. 74-75.

“We must see in the three pictures that are set before us temptations which came to Jesus as he had become aware of his own high vocation; and we must also assume that he deemed his experience relevant to the hopes and desires of his disciples. Otherwise why should he have told it to them?”

Manson, T.W. (1977). [Servant-Messiah: A Study of the Public Ministry of Jesus](#). Baker Book House. 55.

“The heart of the temptation is to be found in an attempt to induce Jesus to be unfaithful to a pattern of Sonship conceived in terms of the relationship between ideal Israel and the divine Father. It is a temptation away from sonship ... Jesus was called to live out in his own experience the sonship that was to have characterized Israel, and relationship with God which involves (1) dependence on him for the provision of needs, (2) trust in his presence without the need for demonstration, and (3) acceptance of sovereignty only on his terms”

Donaldson, Terence (1987). [Jesus on the Mountain](#). Sheffield Academic Press. 100.

Jesus as Adam and Israel

Jesus’ test is portrayed on analogy to the tests of Adam and Eve in the garden and also to Israel’s test of trust in the wilderness. The reader is invited to compare these tests through a variety of clever textual signals and key images.

Jesus and Adam & Eve	Jesus and Israel
Adam & Eve were tested in a garden // Jesus is tested in the wilderness (opposite of a garden!)	Israel is tested in the wilderness for 40 years // Jesus is tested in the wilderness for 40 days
Adam & Eve were tested by the snake // Jesus is tested by the slanderer	Israel is tested by God // Jesus is tested by the slanderer (allowed by Jesus’ Father)
Adam & Eve were given a test of trust related to food (a fruit tree) // Jesus was tested in relation to food (bread)	Exod. 15:25; 16:4 Israel was tested to trust God for water and bread // Jesus is tested in relation to bread
Gen. 1:26-28 Adam & Eve's vocation as rulers of creation is put to the test // Jesus’ destiny to rule as Son of David/God is put to the test	Exod. 19:4-6 Israel’s vocation as a kingdom of priests is tested in the wilderness // Jesus’ vocation as the royal priest is put to the test
<i>Jesus as Adam and Israel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).</i>	

“Jesus, the Son of God, is repeating the experience of Israel in the desert. Having passed through the waters of a new exodus at his baptism, he enters the desert to suffer a time of testing, his forty days of fasting being analogous to Israel’s forty years of wandering. Like Israel, Jesus is tempted by hunger. And, like Israel, Jesus is tempted to idolatry. All-important for a right understanding of our pericope is Deut. 8:2–3: ‘And you shall remember all the way which the Lord your God has led you these forty years in the wilderness, that he might humble you, testing you to know what was in your heart, whether you would keep his commandments, or not. And he humbled you and let you hunger ...’”

Davies, W.D. & Allison, Dale C. (2000). [A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel according to Saint Matthew, Volume 1](#). T&T Clark. 352.

Test #1: Stones and Bread

The tester questions Jesus’ recently announced identity, “If you are the son of God ...” If Jesus truly is the beloved Son of the Father, why on earth should he be going hungry in the desert? Surely the divine Son has the ability to meet his own needs.

This strongly echoes the snake’s words to the woman at the tree, which was an attack on the trustworthy character of God. “Did God really say don’t eat from any tree in the garden?”

Jesus trusts that his Father has a larger purpose in mind, as the larger context of his quotation from [Deuteronomy 8](#) implies.

Deuteronomy 8:2-5 NIV

² Remember how the LORD your God led you all the way in the wilderness these forty years, to humble and test you in order to know what was in your heart, whether or not you would keep his commands. ³ He humbled you, causing you to hunger and then feeding you with manna, which neither you nor your ancestors had known, to teach you that man does not live on bread alone but on every word that comes from the mouth of the LORD. ⁴ Your clothes did not wear out and your feet did not swell during these forty years. ⁵ Know then in your heart that as a father disciplines his son, so the LORD your God disciplines you.

Jesus' trust in God's provision of bread in the desert is a deliberate replay of Israel's struggle to trust that God would provide daily manna bread in the desert (see [Exod. 16](#) and [Num. 11](#)). The slanderer is trying to break Jesus' perfect trust in his Father's care.

Jesus does not say that we don't live by bread at all. Rather, he says that human life is ultimately sustained not only by bread, but by the word of God that provides bread in the first place. And it is to the word of God that Jesus will remain loyal.

"Since Jesus has been led by the Spirit into the wilderness, his fasting corresponds to the will of God. It would thus be a violation of his commitment to the will of God and deny his trust in God's care, if he were to ease his situation by acting on his own authority and change stones into bread ... Obedience to God's word, in which true life is to be found, is of controlling importance."

Konrad, Matthias (2020). [The Gospel according to Matthew: A Commentary](#). Baylor University Press. 54.

"Jesus understood his experience of hunger as God's will for him at the time, and therefore not to be evaded by a self-indulgent use of his undoubted power. As God's son, Jesus would trustingly and obediently comply with his father's purpose, as he will do again on the night in Gethsemane."

France, R.T. (2007). [The Gospel of Matthew](#). Eerdmans. 131.

Test #2: Throw Yourself Down

Jesus' visionary tour takes him to the top of the temple in Jerusalem. He didn't actually climb up to the top. Jesus is still in apocalyptic visionary mode.

The temple's "upper tip" (Grk. *pterugion* / *πτερυγιον*) could technically refer to the highest point of the temple itself or perhaps the pinnacle of the pillared colonade south of the temple proper that stood overlooking the valley below. Either way, it's a drop of some 150 feet.

"Throw yourself down ..." means deliberately create a situation in which the Father will be obligated to save the life of his Son. Instead of trusting the Father's timing for life or death, force God's hand, that is, test your Father's commitment to deliver and care for you as the divine Son.

In this way, Jesus would become the master of the Father, compelling God to act.

“That the Son of God can rely on God’s protection does not ... justify him in acting in such a way that God would be compelled to intervene ... This second temptation is forshadowing the passion story, for when he is arrested, Jesus rejects violent resistance from one of his disciples by pointing out that he could bring from his Father more than twelve legions of angels. But he must fulfill the will of God and thus take death upon himself for the sake of others.”

Konrad, Matthias (2020). [The Gospel According to Matthew: A Commentary](#). Baylor University Press. 55.

The slanderer quotes from [Psalm 91](#), but the whole context is illuminating.

Psalm 91:9-13 NIV*

⁹ If you say, “Yahweh is my refuge,”
and you make the Most High your dwelling,
¹⁰ no harm will overtake you,
no disaster will come near your tent.
¹¹ For he will command his angels concerning you
to guard you in all your ways;
¹² they will lift you up in their hands,
so that you will not strike your foot against a stone.
¹³ You will tread on the lion and the cobra;
you will trample the great lion and the serpent.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The slanderer is twisting this psalm, turning it from a promise of care and victory for the Davidic king into a formula that can be used to coerce the Father into action. Notice the mention of the snake in Psalm 91:13, as if the devil is luring Jesus into trying to conquer him.

Jesus’ counter-quotation comes from another story of Israel’s wilderness journey where God tested Israel’s trust when they lacked water in [Exodus 17:7](#).

Deuteronomy 6:16 NASB*

You shall not put Yahweh your God to the test, as you tested him at Massah.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“The father is not to be compelled. Rather every deed should be an obedient reaction to what he has willed. To use divine power in order to gain self-assurance or to prove what is known to faith, this Jesus cannot do. Any peril he must face and any miracle he is to do must arise solely from obedient service to God’s purpose. When the time comes, the Son will put his life on the line ... but the time is not yet.”

Davies, W.D. & Allison, Dale C. (2000). [A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel according to Saint Matthew, Volume 1](#). T&T Clark. 367.

Test #3: Allegiance and Power

Here, the slanderer changes strategy and no longer tries to undermine Jesus' trust in his Father. He simply makes a bid for allegiance and power.

In the Hebrew Bible, universal dominion over the nations is a common theme in messianic imagery.

Psalm 2:7-8 LEB

⁷ I will tell the decree; Yahweh said to me: "You are my son; today I have begotten you.

⁸ Ask from me and **I will make the nations your heritage**, and your possession the ends of the earth."

Psalm 72:8-11 LEB

⁸ And **may he rule from sea up to sea**, and from the River to the edges of the land.

⁹ Let the desert dwellers bow down before him, and his enemies lick the dust.

¹⁰ Let the kings of Tarshish and the islands bring tribute. Let the kings of Sheba and Seba present gifts,

¹¹ and **let all kings bow down to him. Let all nations serve him.**

Daniel 7:13-14 LEB

¹³ I continued watching in the visions of the night, and look, with the clouds of heaven one like a son of man was coming, and he came to the Ancient of Days, and was presented before him. ¹⁴ And to him was given **dominion and glory and kingship that all the peoples, the nations, and languages would serve him**; his dominion is a dominion without end that will not cease, and his kingdom is one that will not be destroyed.

In the New Testament, the current dominion of the evil one over the nations is a common motif.

2 Corinthians 4:3-4 LEB

³ But if indeed our gospel is veiled, it is veiled among those who are perishing, ⁴ among whom **the god of this age** has blinded the minds of the unbelievers, so that they would not see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.

1 John 5:19 LEB

We know that we are from God, and **the whole world lies in the power of the evil one.**

John 12:31 LEB

Now is the judgment of this world! Now **the ruler of this world** will be thrown out!

Jesus is destined to become the messianic ruler of the world, and at the climax of his story he does in fact gain this very role on the last mountain in Matthew's account.

Matthew 28:16-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ And the eleven apprentices went unto Galilaia,
unto the mountain which Iesus arranged with them. ...

¹⁸ And approaching, Iesus said to them,
"All authority in the sky and on the land has been given to me,

¹⁹ so then, when y'all go, make apprentices of **all the nations**,
immersing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,
²⁰ teaching them to keep everything that I have commanded y'all;
and look, I am with y'all all of the days,
until the conclusion of the age."

The story's conclusion makes clear that Jesus' test is not about whether he will assume cosmic rule over the nations but, instead, his test is about how he will come into that power. How will he gain that power? Will he do it by giving allegiance to his Father or by the more typical ways that humans come into their power and influence? The deeper meaning of this test and Jesus' response is illuminated by two key hyperlinks in this test. The first is the source of Jesus' quotation from Deuteronomy.

Deuteronomy 6:12-14 LEB

¹² then take care for yourself, so that you do not forget Yahweh, who brought you out from the land of Egypt from the house of slavery. ¹³ **You shall fear Yahweh your God, and you shall serve him**, and by his name you shall swear. ¹⁴ You shall not go after other gods from the gods of the peoples who are all around you,

Also crucial is the one other time that Jesus will use the phrase "go away, satan!" (Grk. *υπαγε, σατανα*)

Matthew 4:9-10 NASB

⁹ and he said to him, "All these things I will give you, if you fall down and worship me." ¹⁰ Then Jesus said to him, **"Go away, Satan!** For it is written, 'You shall worship the Lord your God, and serve him only.'"

Matthew 16:22-23 NASB*

²² Peter took him aside and began to rebuke him, saying, "God forbid it, Lord! This shall never happen to you." ²³ But he turned and said to Peter, **"Go away, Satan!** You are a stumbling block to me; for you are not setting your mind on God's interests, but man's."

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jesus hears the voice of the deceiver in the voice of Peter at precisely the moment that Jesus predicted that the Son of Man, who is destined to rule the world, will come into his power by giving up his life for others.

Here in the desert, Jesus wrestles with his vocation to suffer and die in the supreme act of trust that his Father will vindicate him and raise him up to a place of authority and power on the other side of death.

To use the typical human means of gaining power through coercion or violence, to avoid death by fighting or sidelining one's enemies, this would be to "fall down and worship" the evil one. It is only by surrendering to the mysterious will of the Father, even if that should mean death and loss, that Jesus will take up his true calling as THE human image of God.

The Defeated Devil Departs

The slanderer "left" Jesus (Grk. *aphiemi* / *αφιημι*), i.e., "abandoned, released."

After this point, the slanderer has no power or claim on Jesus, and has been defeated as far as Jesus' own will is concerned. This victory is demonstrated narratively through Jesus' exorcisms and healing, as he is able to deliver others from sickness and death because of his own power over the snake. Jesus explicitly said this is what he was doing, plundering the house of a "strong man" to snatch his belongings.

Matthew 12:28-29 Instructor's Translation

²⁸ But **if I throw out *daimons* by means of God's Spirit,**

then, therefore, the kingdom of God has arrived upon you;

²⁹ or, how is someone able to enter into the house of strong-one,
and snatch his belongings,

unless he first binds up the strong-one?

Then he can plunder his house.

Now the only power the slanderer has over Jesus will be through deceiving others, like Judas (see [John 13:2](#)) or Peter (see [Luke 22:31](#)), and ultimately by deceiving the powers that will kill Jesus.

Jesus moves on from this victory describing the Satan as a defeated enemy as far as he's concerned. This victory in the wilderness is what frees Jesus to set others free from his power. And that, of course, is what the next and final unit of Matthew's introduction is all about.

Reflection Question

What are some ways that Jesus' wilderness testing mirrors stories from the Hebrew Bible?